Indian officials found themselves negotiating with the Taliban leadership: Mullah Omar, Mullah Akhtar Mansour and others. After eight days of negotiations, India managed to secure the release of the hostages in exchange for three terrorists in Indian custody: Masood Azhar, who later founded Jaish-e-Mohammed, Omar Saeed Sheikh, who would go on to murder *Wall Street Journal* reporter Daniel Pearl and Mushtaq Ahmad Zargar, who ran training camps in Pakistan. India assessed a close Pakistani role in supporting the hijackers and the Taliban during the hostage crisis, and subsequent developments appeared to corroborate this. In the 1990s, India had supported the Northern Alliance—a loose anti-Taliban coalition—and especially ethnic Tajik leader Ahmad Shah Massoud by extending arms and some aid. As India could not play a security role in Afghanistan on its own, it required cooperating with Iran and Russia, who harboured similar concerns about the Taliban in that period. [33]

In the summer of 2001, Indian and Pakistani leaders met in Agra for a historic two-day summit. The two sides had planned to discuss managing nuclear escalation, the Kashmir dispute, and terrorism. But talks broke down and no agreement was signed, in part due to a lack of trust in Pakistan's leader General Pervez Musharraf, weak commitments on cross-border infiltrations, and the political climate. The failure of the Agra Summit was overshadowed a few months later by the 11 September 2001 attacks in New York and Washington, DC—masterminded by Osama bin Laden and his organization al-Qaeda from a safe haven in Afghanistan—which suddenly made transnational terrorism centred in Afghanistan and Pakistan an international issue. India was supportive of the US invasion of Afghanistan to topple the Taliban government and eliminate al-Qaeda.

But as bin Laden was trapped in the border region of Tora Bora in late 2001, Pakistan-based militants attacked India once again. This time, their target was the Parliament in New Delhi. This incident, in which a high-profile hostage situation was narrowly averted, gave a pretext for Pakistan to withdraw its forces from the Afghan border and redeploy against India. Bin Laden managed to slip into Pakistan, where he would remain in hiding for the next decade. India, meanwhile, authorized a large-scale mobilization